

Mask of Agamemnon

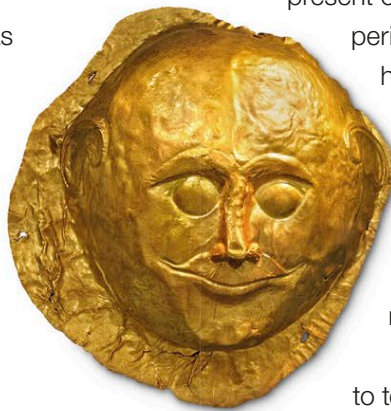
△ Agamemnon depicted in a painting c.1633

A gold death mask, the Mask of Agamemnon is one of the world's most famous – and controversial – archaeological artefacts. It was found covering the face of a body in shaft graves in Mycenae, Greece, in 1876.

Made from a thick sheet of gold that has been hammered over a wooden mould, it depicts the face of a bearded man. Fine textures, such as the eyebrows and beard, were added using a sharp tool. Heinrich Schliemann, the archaeologist who found it, claimed he had “gazed on the face of Agamemnon”, legendary king and leader of the famous attack on ancient Troy. This claim was later refuted when it emerged that the graves, from around 1500 BCE, predated the Trojan War by around three centuries, although the site was still identified as Troy. The name has stuck, however, and the mask is accepted as a genuine artefact by the National Archaeological Museum of Athens, where it remains a highlight today.

I have gazed on the face of Agamemnon

Heinrich **Schliemann**
in a telegram to a Greek newspaper
on finding the mask



Typical ancient Greek death mask

However, critics point to the atypical features – facial hair, separate ear flaps, and distinct eyebrows – none of which are present on other masks of the same period at the site. Schliemann had been suspected of “salting” his previous finds with treasures from other sites, and detractors suggested he may have planted a forgery, or reworked an ancient mask.

Calls have been made to test the age of the mask – ancient gold is impure and contains alloyed minerals that corrode over time, which can help establish age. However, the Archaeological Museum of Athens regards doubts about the mask as unfounded, and it remains one of the world's most intriguing pieces of precious metalwork, as well as a stunning artefact in its own right.



Scene from the Trojan War in a 16th-century Italian fresco, featuring the Trojan horse, with which Agamemnon tricked the Trojans and took the city of Troy

Key dates

c.1500 BCE–1983

